

Dispensational Readings of Acts and the Acts Overlap Model

A historical comparison and a guide to the questions at issue

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A documented comparison of major readings of Acts, followed by the Acts Overlap Model and a guide to further study.

Purpose and scope

Readers of Acts often encounter several answers to a seemingly simple question: how does the Church described in Paul's letters relate to Peter's ministry to Israel and to the events Luke records? The answers affect the way one understands the gospel proclamation, apostolic commissions, baptism, signs, and Israel's continuing promises. This monograph explains the main approaches, then sets out the Acts Overlap Model used by Zay-Marie Press. It does not claim that every dispensationalist fits one fixed school or that all disputes can be settled by a single label.

Historical descriptions below report positions held by others; the account of the Acts Overlap Model states this press's own position. The selected primary texts are identified at the end. The Scripture references invite examination of the passages and do not, by themselves, prove every interpretive conclusion.

Contents

- 1. Why the starting point matters · 2
- 2. Early dispensationalism and the Acts 28 question · 2
- 3. Mid-Acts writers and the Pauline commission · 3
- 4. Comparing the questions without flattening the writers · 4
- 5. The Acts Overlap Model · 4
- 6. Testing the model against difficult Acts passages · 5
- 7. Where to continue in the Digital Studies · 7
- Selected sources · 8

1. Why the starting point matters

The disagreement is more precise than a choice among Acts 2, Acts 9, Acts 13, and Acts 28. Interpreters must ask what they mean by “church,” whether an apostolic commission changes when its messenger addresses a different audience, what a narrated action authorizes for later readers, and whether Israel’s prophetic calling remains operative during Paul’s ministry. A date offered without answers to those questions can hide rather than solve the real disagreement.

Acts 2 reports Peter addressing Israel at Pentecost. Acts 9 records the risen Christ’s call of Paul. Acts 13 narrates a public setting apart for a particular work. Acts 15 records the Jerusalem meeting over Gentiles, circumcision, and the recognition of ministries. Acts 28 records Paul’s application of Isaiah’s judgment oracle to the Jews gathered in Rome. These are distinct events. Treating all five as interchangeable “starts” ignores their different narrative functions.

The governing question of this monograph is therefore twofold: when does the Mystery Program revealed through Paul begin, and how should readers understand the continued activity of Israel’s Prophecy Program alongside Paul’s ministry? The answer here is Acts 9 for the former and concurrent operation through Acts 28 for the latter. This is the Acts Overlap Model. It is presented after the historical survey so readers can see both what it shares with earlier writers and where it makes its own claim.

2. Early dispensationalism and the Acts 28 question

Darby and the distinction between Israel and the Church

John Nelson Darby was a major nineteenth-century figure in the formation of dispensational thought. His writing and the Plymouth Brethren movement pressed readers to take Israel’s prophetic promises seriously and to distinguish the Church’s calling from Israel’s national hope. In “Church and Privileges,” Darby places the formation of the Body at Pentecost through the coming of the Holy Spirit. The later spread of dispensational interpretation in English-speaking settings owed much to developments beyond Darby, including the influence of the Scofield Reference Bible. Neither should be treated as if he articulated every position adopted by later Mid-Acts writers.

A reader can affirm a distinction between Israel and the Church while disagreeing about the Church’s historical beginning. The historical value of Darby in this survey lies in the questions his approach made difficult to ignore: to whom was a promise addressed, and what follows when the passage is read in that audience’s setting? The answer given by the Acts Overlap Model goes further by identifying a distinct Mystery beginning with Paul in Acts 9.

Bullinger and the later Acts 28 position

The Companion Bible, appendix 181, assigns Acts 28 a decisive role: it says the national offer to Israel ends there and places the formation of “the church which is His body” after the close of Acts. This appendix is associated with Bullinger’s Companion Bible, whose complete publication followed his death; its editorial history should not be collapsed into an unqualified claim about every earlier writing of Bullinger. The Acts 28 reading gives a different account of Paul’s earlier and later letters from the one advanced here.

Acts 28:25–28 matters in the Acts Overlap Model, but its role is specific: Israel’s Prophecy Program reaches national judicial suspension there. It is not the beginning of the Body of Christ, and it does not erase the Mystery ministry already operating in Paul’s Acts-period work. The suspension of national prophetic operation also does not cancel the future fulfillment of Israel’s promises. A comparison of these readings must distinguish the importance of Acts 28 from the claim that everything distinctive to the Body begins there.

3. Mid-Acts writers and the Pauline commission

J. C. O’Hair and Charles F. Baker pressed distinctions between the commissions given to the Twelve and to Paul, between Israel’s Kingdom proclamation and Paul’s ministry to the Body, and between an event recorded in Scripture and an instruction governing believers today. O’Hair’s and Baker’s writings are primary witnesses to those arguments. Baker’s work with O’Hair and his role in the school later known as Grace Bible College are documented by the institution, now Grace Christian University.

Baker’s *A Dispensational Theology* provides a sharper comparison than the original draft allowed. In its conclusion on the Body’s beginning (printed p. 485), he rejects Pentecost and Acts 28, considers Acts 9, and favors Paul’s separation for ministry in Acts 13. Elsewhere (printed pp. 566–567), he expressly denies that two distinct dispensations were operating at the same time in the latter part of Acts. His explanation of Acts-era practices is therefore not the Acts Overlap Model’s claim of concurrent Prophecy and Mystery operation. Reporting his Acts 13 position without this disagreement would mislead the reader.

Cornelius R. Stam, though underdeveloped in the original draft, belongs in any useful account of Mid-Acts interpretation. His published writing explicitly distinguishes Paul’s unique apostleship and the Body of Christ from a Pentecost beginning. These writers should still be read individually. “Mid-Acts” names a family of arguments, not a guarantee that every author gives identical answers about timing, baptism, gifts, or the scope of Paul’s ministry.

Les Feldick extended this field of teaching to a broad lay audience. In his Book 19 Acts lessons he gives Acts 9 exceptional importance and distinguishes the believing Jewish assembly from the Body of Christ; Book 44 includes his lesson “Paul—First in the Body of Christ.” These are better anchors for describing his teaching than assigning him an unverified combined Acts

9/Acts 13 position. Likewise, initials alone cannot support detailed theological profiles of contemporary teachers. Those profiles are excluded here.

A fair historical survey needs to preserve disagreement even where the writer of this monograph has reached a firm conclusion. It is reasonable to say that the Acts 28 and Mid-Acts approaches place different weight on Paul's earlier ministry; it is not reasonable to assign every individual an exact point on a chart without textual evidence. The comparison that follows therefore distinguishes broad approaches from claims about named people.

4. Comparing the questions without flattening the writers

Question	Common approach in the debate	Acts Overlap Model
Pentecost	Often treated as the beginning of the Church in classical accounts.	Acts 1–8 continue Israel's Prophecy Program; the Mystery begins with Paul in Acts 9.
Paul's call	Mid-Acts writers emphasize Paul's distinct commission, with differences among them about its historical articulation.	The Mystery Program and the Body begin in Acts 9; Paul has one distinct Mystery apostleship.
Acts 13	Baker favors Paul's separation for ministry here (A Dispensational Theology, p. 485).	A public commissioning for work already grounded in Paul's Acts 9 calling; no new program begins.
Acts 28	Acts 28 approaches assign it a defining boundary for the Body or its revelation.	Israel's national Prophecy Program is suspended; the Mystery Program continues.
Acts events	Schools differ about the force of narrated baptisms, signs, and Jewish observances.	Each event is tested by audience, content, purpose, and governing instruction; narration alone does not impose a rule on the Body.

This table describes approaches at a high level. It is not a substitute for a writer-by-writer comparison with primary citations. In particular, a historical position should not be labeled a form of the Acts Overlap Model merely because it notices complexity in Acts. The model makes a definite claim about the start and concurrent operation of two distinct programs.

5. The Acts Overlap Model

Two programs with distinct beginnings and assignments

Israel's Prophecy Program begins before Acts 9 and remains operative in Acts 1–8. The Mystery Program of the Body of Christ begins with Paul's calling in Acts 9. From Acts 9 through Acts 28, both programs operate concurrently. At Acts 28:25–28 Israel's national Prophecy Program

reaches judicial suspension; the Mystery Program continues beyond that point. Suspension does not mean Israel's covenants are abolished or her prophetic future assigned to the Body.

Concurrency does not blend the programs. Israel remains a covenant nation with an earthly Kingdom hope. The Body is the non-covenantal, heavenly people associated with the Mystery revealed through Paul. Peter's Kingdom commission and Paul's Mystery commission are distinct apostolic lines operating during the same historical period. Paul possesses one apostleship and stewardship, exclusively associated with the Mystery; speaking to Jews or citing their Scriptures gives him no second Prophecy commission.

One Pauline commission and more than one audience

Luke first records Paul preaching Christ in synagogues after his Acts 9 call (Acts 9:20). Later he reasons with Jewish hearers from the Scriptures (Acts 17:2–3), while his ministry to Gentiles expands. A Jewish audience and a prophetic text do not make Paul the administrator of Israel's program. Conversely, Paul's name on a page does not automatically make every statement distinctive Mystery doctrine. The message must be read for its content, audience, revelatory source, and assigned authority.

Acts 13:46, 18:6, and 19:9 record local turns following Jewish opposition. They are real ministry decisions, but Paul subsequently addresses Jews in other places. They therefore do not serve as successive national suspension points or later beginnings of the Mystery. Israel's national judicial suspension belongs to the Acts 28 scene; Paul's distinctive Mystery commission began in Acts 9.

A controlled way to read narrated actions

Before treating an event as a present requirement, ask: Who acts or speaks? Who is addressed? What is the content or practice? What purpose does the passage actually state? Which program's instruction governs the audience? Does Paul's teaching for the Body impose the practice, permit it, or distinguish it from the Body's standing in Christ? These questions keep historical participation from being mistaken for doctrinal obligation.

The answer cannot be inferred merely from an event's date, the presence of a sign, or Paul's involvement. Acts is inspired history that teaches readers about what God did. The question whether an action binds the Body requires a separate argument from the governing revelation. This protects both programs from having their commands, signs, covenants, or hopes transferred by historical proximity.

6. Testing the model against difficult Acts passages

Timothy and the Jerusalem Council

Acts 16:3 says Paul circumcised Timothy because of the Jews in the places where they would minister. The immediate reason supplied by Luke is important. Galatians 5:2–6, by contrast,

resists circumcision when it is treated as a condition of right standing. The model reads Timothy's act as a voluntary accommodation within Israel's still-operative prophetic setting. It does not make Paul an administrator of that program or establish circumcision as a requirement for Gentiles in the Body. Acts 15 and Galatians 2:7–9 deserve separate attention because the Council and recognition of ministries address more than Timothy's particular case.

Temple participation

In Acts 21:23–26, Paul participates in a temple-related purification arrangement at the request of Jerusalem believers who are concerned about reports concerning his teaching to Jews. The episode calls for care about what James says, what Paul does, and what Luke leaves unexplained. It should not be described as proof that Paul held a second Prophecy apostleship. Nor does the action place the Body under the Mosaic Law. During the overlap Paul could accommodate Jewish circumstances while his own commission remained Mystery.

Signs and baptisms

Acts 19:1–7 and 19:11–12 report Spirit reception, tongues, prophecy, and extraordinary healings in particular contexts. These signs occurred during the overlap, but the presence of Paul does not alone determine their programmatic assignment. The passage's audience and stated purpose must be examined; where the text does not supply a complete explanation, the monograph should not invent one. The continuing narrative is no warrant to impose every sign on every believer.

Acts 18:8 reports that many Corinthians heard, believed, and were baptized; it does not explicitly say Paul personally baptized them. Acts 19:5 likewise describes baptism without naming Paul as its administrator. Paul does explicitly say that he baptized a small number at Corinth while distinguishing his commission to preach from a commission to baptize (1 Cor. 1:14–17). These texts require careful comparison. The mere occurrence of an Acts baptism cannot, on its own, establish the Body's governing baptismal instruction. Study 42 treats that question directly.

The significance of Acts 28

Acts 28:25–28 closes Paul's address to Jewish hearers with Isaiah's judgment oracle and the statement that God's salvation is sent to Gentiles. In this framework it marks the national judicial suspension of Israel's Prophecy Program. Readers should compare it with earlier local Jewish refusals and with Romans 11's account of Israel's hardening. Those earlier events matter, but they are not identical to the national judgment at the close of Acts. The Mystery ministry continues after Acts 28, while Israel's future prophetic promises remain awaiting fulfillment.

7. Where to continue in the Digital Studies

This monograph gives the historical setting and states the interpretive architecture. Each study below takes up a narrower question. The routes are selective; readers may begin with the question that brought them here.

If your question is...	Continue with...	What the study adds
Did the Body begin at Pentecost or with Paul?	The Beginning of the Body of Christ; Acts 9 and the Beginning of Mystery	The first study treats the Body's beginning; the second tests what Acts 9 contributes to the argument.
How can Peter and Paul both appear in Acts?	Peter and Paul: Distinct Apostolic Commissions; The Jerusalem Council	The first compares commissions; the second examines their recognition and the Gentile circumcision question in Acts 15.
How should I interpret Peter's Pentecost appeal?	The Gospel of the Kingdom; Understanding Acts 2:38	The first identifies the announced Kingdom and audience; the second applies that setting to Peter's specific command.
Does an Acts event become my rule?	Why Acts Is Not a Universal Experience Manual; One Baptism	The first supplies a method for judging narrative claims; the second traces baptism passages toward Paul's instruction for the Body.
What changes at Acts 28?	Israel's Judicial Blinding; The Mystery Revealed Through Paul	The first follows Israel's hardening; the second establishes the Mystery already revealed through Paul.
What gospel did Paul preach?	The Gospel of the Grace of God; The Gospel of the Kingdom	Read both to distinguish the messages by audience, content, and promised setting.

The Study Connections guide on the Digital Studies site offers wider reading routes across the full catalog. The monograph's purpose is to make the historical and theological questions intelligible; the focused studies allow readers to examine the passages and arguments in depth.

Conclusion

Dispensational writers have differed about the Church's beginning and the place of Acts 28 because they make different judgments about audiences, revelation, commissions, and the force of narrative. A useful comparison states those judgments fairly and leaves each writer responsible for his own documented claims. The Acts Overlap Model offered here makes its own chronology explicit: the Mystery begins with Paul in Acts 9, both programs operate concurrently through Acts 28, and Israel's national prophetic operation is then suspended while the Mystery continues. The reader can test the model by following the actual passages, the distinct assignments they disclose, and the questions raised by Acts-era conduct.

Selected sources

Scripture: Acts 2; 9; 13; 15; 16; 18; 19; 21; 28; Galatians 1–2; 5; Romans 11; 1 Corinthians 1; Ephesians 3. Scriptural interpretation in this monograph is the author's.

J. C. O'Hair, "The Gospel, the Kingdom and the Church," Berean Bible Society archive.[\[Read source\]](#)

Charles F. Baker, "The Great Commission," Berean Bible Society archive, parts 1–4.[\[Read source\]](#)

Cornelius R. Stam, "Christ and His Body," Berean Bible Society archive.[\[Read source\]](#)

Grace Christian University, "History" and "Past Presidents," for Baker's institutional history.[\[Read source\]](#)

John Nelson Darby, "Church and Privileges," Collected Writings, Doctrinal 9.[\[Read source\]](#)

The Companion Bible, appendix 181, "The Dispensational Position of the Book of the Acts," §§2, 6.[\[Read source\]](#)

Charles F. Baker, A Dispensational Theology, printed pp. 485, 566–567.[\[Read source\]](#)

Les Feldick, Through the Bible with Les Feldick, Book 19, Acts 9 and Acts 13 lessons.[\[Read source\]](#)

Les Feldick, Through the Bible with Les Feldick, Book 44, "Paul—First in the Body of Christ."[\[Read source\]](#)